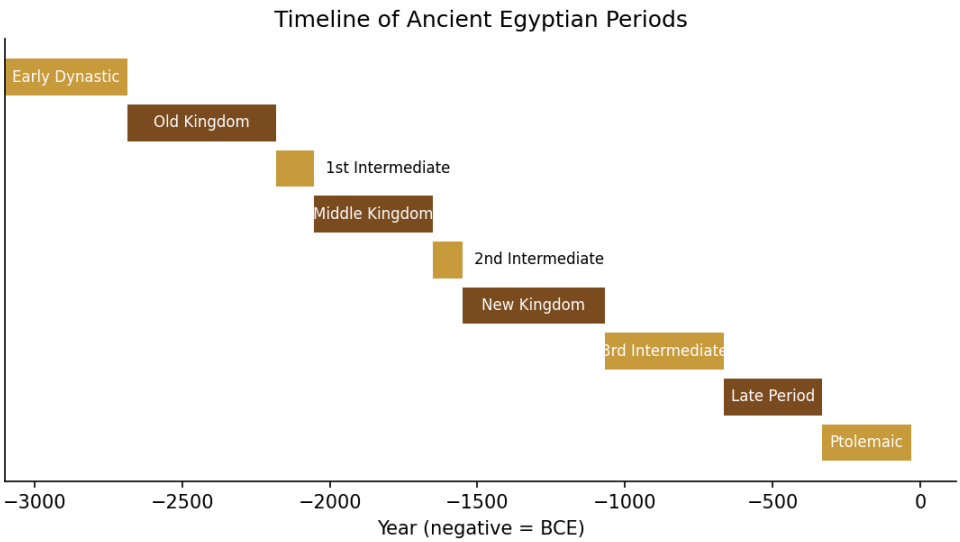
A HISTORY OF ANCIENT EGYPT

A Long-Form Reference



From the Unification of the Two Lands to the Roman Conquest

Prepared as a long-form, text-heavy test document for retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) systems. Dates are approximate.

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1. The Gift of the Nile: Land and People

Ancient Egypt was one of the longest-lived civilisations in human history. From the unification of the Nile Valley around 3100 BCE to the death of Cleopatra VII in 30 BCE, a span of roughly three thousand years, the Egyptians developed a distinctive culture that left its mark on architecture, religion, writing, art and statecraft. To place this duration in perspective, the time that separates Cleopatra from the building of the Great Pyramid is greater than the time that separates Cleopatra from the present day. The Greek historian Herodotus, who visited Egypt in the fifth century BCE, famously described the country as the gift of the Nile, and although the phrase is a simplification, it captures the central truth that the river made everything else possible.

The Nile flows northward for more than 6,600 kilometres from its sources in the African highlands to the Mediterranean Sea, and in Egypt it cuts a narrow green ribbon through an otherwise arid landscape. The Egyptians themselves recognised this contrast and called their homeland Kemet, the Black Land, after the dark fertile silt left by the flood, while they called the surrounding desert Deshret, the Red Land. Most of the population lived within a few kilometres of the river, in a valley that is seldom more than twenty kilometres wide, and in the broad triangular Delta where the river divides into several branches before reaching the sea. The country was traditionally divided into Upper Egypt, the southern valley, and Lower Egypt, the northern Delta, and this duality remained fundamental to the way kings presented themselves for the whole of Egyptian history, as rulers of the Two Lands.

The rhythm of life was set by the annual inundation. Each summer, rains in the Ethiopian highlands swelled the river, and from roughly June to September the floodwaters spread across the valley floor, depositing fresh silt and soaking the soil. When the water receded, farmers sowed their seed in the damp earth, and the crops grew over the following months until the harvest in the spring. The Egyptians divided the year into three seasons based on this cycle, named Akhet, the flood, Peret, the emergence or growing season, and Shemu, the harvest, as shown in Figure 1.1. A good flood meant plentiful grain and a prosperous state,

while a poor flood, or one that was too high, could bring famine and political instability.

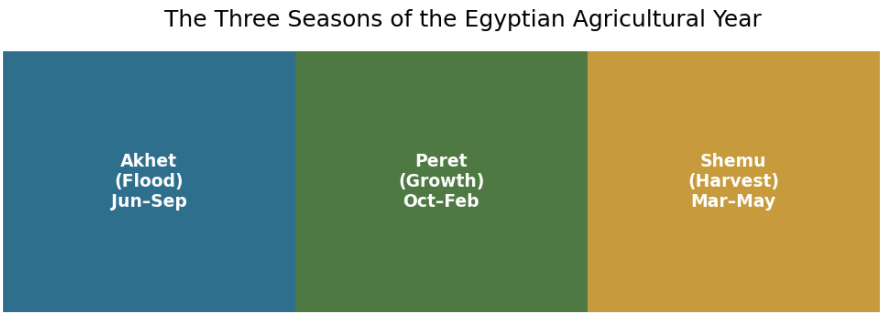


Figure 1.1: The three seasons of the Egyptian agricultural year.

The desert on either side of the valley provided protection from invasion and a rich supply of resources. The eastern desert contained gold, copper and a variety of semi-precious stones, while the western desert held oases that served as outposts and trading centres. To the south, the cataracts of the Nile, rapids that made navigation difficult, formed a natural boundary between Egypt and the land of Nubia, and to the north the Mediterranean limited access by sea. This relative isolation allowed Egyptian civilisation to develop with a high degree of continuity, although the Egyptians were never entirely cut off from their neighbours and traded actively with Nubia, the Levant, the Aegean and the Land of Punt, a region on the Red Sea coast that supplied incense, ebony and exotic animals.

The river was also the main highway. Because the Nile flows north and the prevailing wind blows south, boats could drift downstream with the current and sail upstream with the wind, which made transport of people, grain and heavy stone remarkably efficient. This ease of movement helped to unify the country politically and made it possible to transport the enormous blocks of granite from Aswan that were used in temples and royal monuments. It is no coincidence that the Egyptian hieroglyph for travelling south shows a boat with a sail, while the sign for travelling north shows a boat without one.

This document presents the history of ancient Egypt in a continuous narrative, from the earliest settlements to the Roman conquest, followed by chapters on religion, society, writing and science, and a final chapter on the modern rediscovery of the civilisation. Dates are approximate, especially for the earliest

periods, and scholars sometimes disagree by several decades about the reigns of individual kings. The chronology follows the broadly accepted framework summarised in Table 1.1 and Figure 1.2. This text has been prepared as a long-form reference document for testing text-heavy document retrieval and question-answering systems.

Table 1.1: Major periods of ancient Egyptian history (approximate dates BCE)

Period	Dates (BCE)	Capital / centre	Defining features
Early Dynastic	3100–2686	Memphis / Thinis	Unification, hieroglyphs, first kings
Old Kingdom	2686–2181	Memphis	Pyramid building, strong central state
First Intermediate	2181–2055	Heracleopolis / Thebes	Fragmentation, regional rulers
Middle Kingdom	2055–1650	Thebes / Itjtawy	Reunification, classical literature
Second Intermediate	1650–1550	Avaris / Thebes	Hyksos rule in the north
New Kingdom	1550–1069	Thebes / Pi-Ramesses	Empire, great temples, Valley of the Kings
Third Intermediate	1069–664	Tanis / Thebes	Divided rule, Libyan and Nubian kings
Late Period	664–332	Sais / Memphis	Saite revival, Persian rule
Ptolemaic	332–30	Alexandria	Greek dynasty, Cleopatra VII

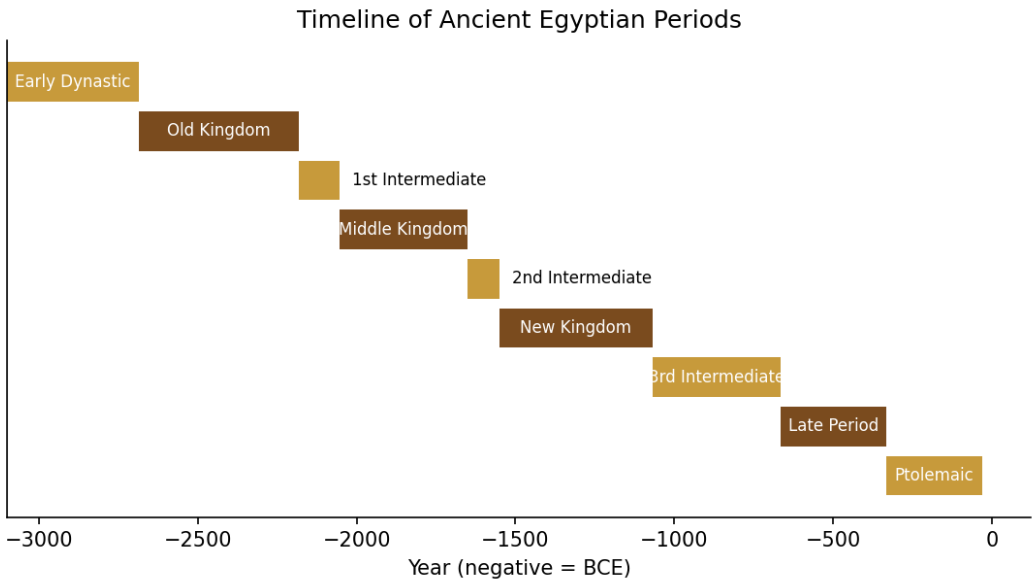


Figure 1.2: Timeline of ancient Egyptian periods.

2. Predynastic Egypt and the Unification of the Two Lands

Human presence in the Nile Valley goes back hundreds of thousands of years, but the story of Egyptian civilisation begins in earnest in the Neolithic period. Around 5500 BCE, communities in the Fayum and in Upper Egypt began to herd cattle, sheep and goats and to cultivate wheat and barley, crops that had spread from the Near East. As the Sahara became progressively drier from about 5000 BCE onward, people from the surrounding regions moved toward the river, and this concentration of population in the valley was one of the preconditions for the emergence of a complex society.

The Predynastic period is divided by archaeologists into cultural phases named after the sites where they were first identified, such as Badari, Naqada and Maadi. The Naqada culture, which flourished in Upper Egypt from about 4000 to 3100 BCE, is particularly important. Over the course of these centuries, cemeteries show a growing difference in wealth between burials, with some individuals interred in large tombs filled with fine pottery, stone vessels, copper objects and imported goods such as lapis lazuli from Afghanistan. At sites like Hierakonpolis, Naqada and Abydos, local chiefs emerged who controlled trade and agricultural surplus, and the earliest signs of royal ideology, such as the motif of a ruler smiting enemies, begin to appear on decorated objects.

The process by which these regional centres were joined into a single state is only partly understood. Later Egyptian tradition credited a king called Menes with uniting the country and founding the capital at Memphis, near the point where the Delta meets the valley. Modern scholars usually identify Menes with either King Narmer or King Hor-Aha, and the Narmer Palette, a carved slate object found at Hierakonpolis, is often interpreted as a commemoration of a victory over northern enemies. On one side the king wears the white crown of Upper Egypt, and on the other he wears the red crown of Lower Egypt, symbolising the political unification, although it is likely that the process of consolidation unfolded over several generations rather than in a single campaign.

The first two dynasties, known as the Early Dynastic Period, saw the consolidation of state institutions. The kings were buried at Abydos in large mud-brick tombs surrounded by the graves of retainers, and officials began to be buried in mastaba tombs at Saqqara, the cemetery of the new capital. During this period hieroglyphic writing developed from a collection of labels and symbols into a full system capable of recording the Egyptian language. Administration was organised through a bureaucracy of scribes who collected taxes in grain and labour, and the country was divided into administrative districts that the Greeks later called nomes.

The ideological foundations of kingship were also laid in this period. The king was regarded as the earthly embodiment of the god Horus, and on his death he was identified with Osiris, the god of the afterlife, while his successor became the new Horus. The royal titulary, a set of names that each king adopted, expressed different aspects of his role, and by the end of the Old Kingdom it comprised five names, including the birth name enclosed in a cartouche. This concept of divine kingship, in which the ruler was responsible for maintaining Maat, the cosmic order of truth and justice, remained the central pillar of Egyptian political thought for the next three thousand years.

By the end of the Second Dynasty the Egyptian state was already a sophisticated organisation, capable of mobilising labour, collecting resources from distant mines and managing a calendar. The administrative skills developed in this formative period would soon be applied on a staggering scale in the construction of the first monumental stone buildings in the world.

3. The Old Kingdom: The Age of the Pyramids

The Old Kingdom, covering the Third to the Sixth Dynasties from about 2686 to 2181 BCE, is often called the Age of the Pyramids. Its first great ruler, Djoser of the Third Dynasty, ordered the construction of a funerary complex at Saqqara designed by his chancellor Imhotep, who is remembered by later generations as an architect, physician and sage. Instead of the traditional mud-brick mastaba, Imhotep built a tomb of cut limestone with six successive levels, producing the Step Pyramid, which rises to about 62 metres and is the earliest large stone building known. The complex included courtyards, chapels and dummy buildings that allowed the king to enjoy the festivals of the afterlife for eternity.

The Fourth Dynasty marks the high point of pyramid building. Sneferu, the founder of the dynasty, built at least three major pyramids, including the Bent Pyramid and the Red Pyramid at Dahshur. The Bent Pyramid has an unusual shape because the builders changed the angle of the walls from about 54 degrees to about 43 degrees halfway up, probably because of structural problems, while the Red Pyramid, with its constant lower angle, was the first true smooth-sided pyramid. These experiments provided the technical knowledge that made the Great Pyramid of Giza possible.

Sneferu's son Khufu, called Cheops by the Greeks, built the Great Pyramid at Giza around 2560 BCE. The structure originally stood about 146.6 metres high and was constructed from an estimated 2.3 million blocks of limestone, with granite beams used for the roofs of the internal chambers. It remained the tallest man-made structure in the world for nearly four thousand years. The discovery in 2013 of the Wadi al-Jarf papyri, the diary of an official called Merer, gave direct evidence of how limestone from the Tura quarries was transported by boat to Giza during Khufu's reign. The workers who built the pyramid were not slaves, as popular legend long held, but paid labourers who were housed, fed and buried in tombs near the monuments.

Table 3.1: Principal pyramids of the Old Kingdom

Pyramid	Pharaoh	Location	Dynasty	Original height
Step Pyramid	Djoser	Saqqara	3rd	≈ 62 m
Meidum Pyramid	Huni / Sneferu	Meidum	3rd–4th	≈ 92 m
Bent Pyramid	Sneferu	Dahshur	4th	≈ 104.7 m
Red Pyramid	Sneferu	Dahshur	4th	≈ 104 m
Great Pyramid	Khufu	Giza	4th	≈ 146.6 m
Pyramid of Khafre	Khafre	Giza	4th	≈ 143.5 m
Pyramid of Menkaure	Menkaure	Giza	4th	≈ 65.5 m
Pyramid of Unas	Unas	Saqqara	5th	≈ 43 m

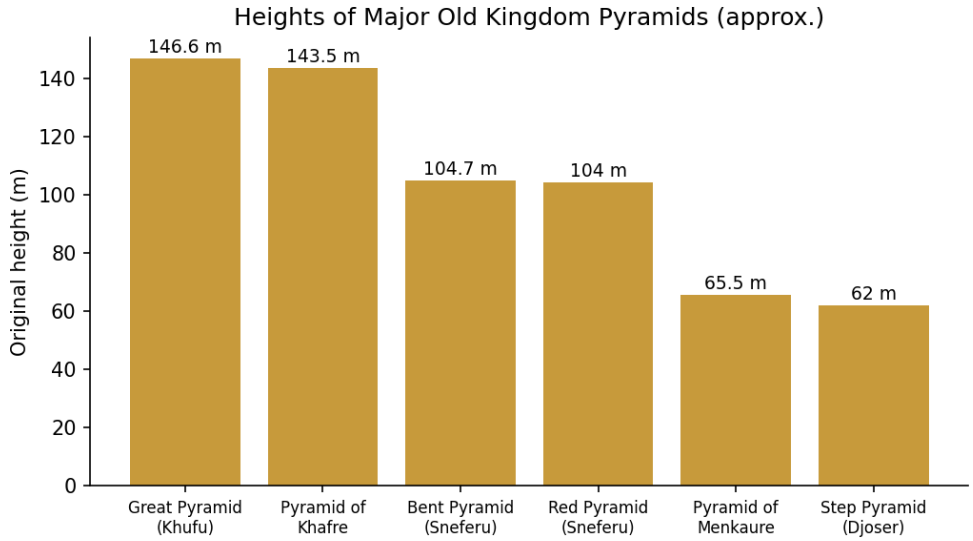


Figure 3.1: Original heights of the best-known Old Kingdom pyramids.

Khufu's successors Khafre and Menkaure built smaller pyramids at Giza, and Khafre is credited with the Great Sphinx, a colossal limestone figure with a lion's body and a royal head that guards the causeway leading to his pyramid temple. By the Fifth Dynasty pyramids became smaller and less well built, but their burial chambers began to be inscribed with the Pyramid Texts, the oldest known religious writings in the world, a collection of spells intended to help the dead king ascend to the sky and join the gods. The growing importance of the sun god Ra in this period is reflected in the building of sun temples and in the inclusion of Ra in the royal titulary.

The Old Kingdom state was highly centralised. A vizier served as the king's chief minister, supervising the treasury, the judiciary and the building projects, and a network of provincial governors collected taxes and organised labour. Over time,

however, the system began to change. The king granted land and tax exemptions to temples and to officials, and provincial governors, called nomarchs, gradually made their offices hereditary and developed independent power bases. The reign of Pepi II of the Sixth Dynasty, which according to tradition lasted more than ninety years, was followed by the collapse of central authority. Climate change, a series of low Nile floods and political fragmentation combined to bring the Old Kingdom to an end around 2181 BCE.

4. The First Intermediate Period and the Middle Kingdom

The period that followed the Old Kingdom, from about 2181 to 2055 BCE, is called the First Intermediate Period. Egyptian texts of later centuries describe it as a time of chaos, hunger and social upheaval, and some, like the Admonitions of Ipuwer, lament that the poor had become rich and the rich had become poor. Modern research has shown that the picture is more nuanced: provincial centres flourished, local art developed new styles, and nomarchs recorded their efforts to feed their people during famines. Nevertheless, the absence of a strong central authority meant that the country was divided between rival dynasties, one based at Heracleopolis in the north and another at Thebes in the south.

The conflict was resolved by Mentuhotep II of the Eleventh Dynasty, a Theban king who reunified Egypt around 2055 BCE after a long struggle against the northern rulers. He built a remarkable mortuary temple at Deir el-Bahari, on the west bank of the Nile opposite Thebes, which later served as inspiration for Queen Hatshepsut's famous temple next door. His reunification inaugurated the Middle Kingdom, a period that the Egyptians themselves regarded as a classical age of literature, art and moral values.

The Twelfth Dynasty, founded by Amenemhat I around 1985 BCE, was the strongest dynasty of the Middle Kingdom. Amenemhat moved the capital to a new city called Itjtawy, near the entrance to the Fayum, and reasserted royal control over the provinces by curbing the power of the nomarchs. He also introduced the practice of co-regency, in which a king would appoint his heir as co-ruler during his lifetime to ensure a smooth succession, a custom that was followed by many of his successors. The dynasty's kings undertook large-scale irrigation projects in the Fayum depression, turning the area into one of the most productive agricultural regions in the country.

Senusret III, who ruled from about 1878 to 1839 BCE, is one of the most remarkable kings of the period. He conducted military campaigns in Nubia and built a chain of massive mud-brick fortresses, including Buhen and Semna, along

the second cataract of the Nile to control trade and mark the southern frontier. His portraits, which show a king with heavy-lidded eyes and a careworn face, broke with the idealised youthful look of earlier royal statues and convey a new sense of the burdens of kingship. Under his rule the powers of the provincial governors were reduced, and a larger and more professional bureaucracy emerged.

The literature of the Middle Kingdom is regarded as the classical tradition of the Egyptian language, known as Middle Egyptian. Works such as the Story of Sinuhe, the tale of an official who fled Egypt after the death of Amenemhat I and lived among the people of the Levant before returning home in old age, the Tale of the Eloquent Peasant, and the Instructions of Amenemhat are masterpieces of narrative and rhetoric. Scribes continued to copy and study these texts for centuries, and Middle Egyptian remained the language of monumental inscriptions until the end of pharaonic civilisation.

The Thirteenth Dynasty, which followed the Twelfth, saw a rapid succession of short reigns, and central power weakened again. At the same time, Asiatic settlers who had been drawn to the eastern Delta by trade and opportunity gained increasing influence in the north. This slow disintegration set the stage for a new period of division and for the arrival of foreign rulers.

5. The Second Intermediate Period and the Rise of the New Kingdom

Around 1650 BCE, the Egyptian state again broke up into smaller realms. A group of rulers of Canaanite origin, whom the Egyptians called Heqa-khasut, meaning rulers of foreign lands, and whom the Greeks later called the Hyksos, established control over the eastern Delta from their capital at Avaris, today's Tell el-Dab'a. The Hyksos are remembered in later Egyptian tradition as brutal invaders, but archaeological evidence suggests that they adopted many Egyptian customs, including hieroglyphic writing and royal titles, while also introducing new technologies. The horse-drawn chariot, the composite bow, improved bronze working and new types of fortifications appeared in Egypt in this period.

Meanwhile a native Egyptian dynasty, the Seventeenth, maintained its rule from Thebes in the south, and a third power, the Kingdom of Kush, was emerging further south in Nubia. The Theban kings eventually challenged the Hyksos. An inscribed tablet records that Kamose, the last king of the Seventeenth Dynasty, was frustrated at sharing the country with an Asiatic ruler in the north and a Nubian ruler in the south, and he launched a campaign that brought Theban forces to the gates of Avaris. The mummy of Seqenenre Tao, Kamose's father or brother, bears wounds to the skull that suggest that he died in battle or was executed.

The war of liberation was completed by Ahmose I, who expelled the Hyksos around 1550 BCE and reunified Egypt, founding the Eighteenth Dynasty and the New Kingdom. Ahmose also campaigned in Nubia and in the Levant, laying the foundation for the empire that his successors would build. The experience of foreign rule had a profound effect on Egyptian attitudes: the country now felt the need to create a buffer of territory around its borders, and the army, equipped with chariots and new weapons, became a major institution and a path to power for ambitious men.

The early kings of the Eighteenth Dynasty, Amenhotep I and Thutmose I, extended Egyptian control southward as far as the Fourth Cataract and

northeastward to the Euphrates. Thutmose I is also the first king known to have been buried in the Valley of the Kings, a hidden desert valley on the west bank at Thebes, rather than in a prominent pyramid that could be easily robbed. His tomb was cut deep into the rock, and its location was kept secret, while his mortuary temple was built separately on the edge of the cultivation. This separation of tomb and temple became standard for the next five centuries.

6. The New Kingdom: Egypt as an Imperial Power

The New Kingdom, from about 1550 to 1069 BCE, was the era of Egypt's greatest power and wealth. Its monuments, such as the temples of Karnak and Luxor, the tombs of the Valley of the Kings and the colossal statues of Abu Simbel, are among the most famous in the world, and many of its rulers, including Hatshepsut, Akhenaten, Tutankhamun and Ramesses II, are household names. Egyptian armies campaigned in Nubia and Syria-Palestine, tribute poured into the treasury, and Thebes, home of the god Amun, became the religious capital of an empire.

Hatshepsut, the daughter of Thutmose I, ruled Egypt for about twenty years in the fifteenth century BCE. After the death of her husband Thutmose II she served first as regent for her young stepson Thutmose III, and then around 1473 BCE she assumed the full titles of a pharaoh, adopting royal regalia including the false beard and appearing in some statues in male form. Her reign was a time of peace and prosperity, and she is best known for her trading expedition to the Land of Punt, which is depicted in relief at her mortuary temple at Deir el-Bahari. The expedition returned with myrrh trees, ebony, ivory and exotic animals. After her death Thutmose III, and later perhaps his son, ordered many of her images to be removed or hacked out, though the motive remains debated.

Thutmose III is often called the Napoleon of Egypt because of his military successes. In a series of seventeen campaigns he extended Egyptian control to northern Syria, and his victory at the Battle of Megiddo, around 1457 BCE, against a coalition of Canaanite city-states led by the king of Kadesh, is the earliest battle in history for which a detailed account survives. The campaigns brought wealth, captives and tribute, and Egyptian influence reached its greatest geographical extent. Under his successors, particularly Amenhotep III, who reigned from about 1390 to 1352 BCE, Egypt enjoyed unprecedented prosperity and diplomatic prestige, and the Amarna letters, a cache of clay tablets, show the king exchanging gifts and marriage alliances with the rulers of Babylon, Mitanni and Hatti.

The son of Amenhotep III, Amenhotep IV, initiated one of the most radical episodes in Egyptian history. In the fifth year of his reign he changed his name to Akhenaten, meaning effective for the Aten, and promoted the worship of the sun disc Aten above all other gods. He founded a new capital, Akhetaten, now known as Amarna, in Middle Egypt, and closed the temples of Amun. Art of the period, the Amarna style, is distinctive, with elongated skulls, slender limbs and intimate scenes of the royal family. His wife Nefertiti, whose painted limestone bust is one of the most recognised works of ancient art, appears in unusually prominent roles. After Akhenaten's death the old religion was restored and Amarna was abandoned.

The boy king Tutankhamun, who came to the throne at about the age of nine and died around 1323 BCE at about nineteen, would be a minor figure in history had his tomb not survived almost intact. The discovery of the tomb by Howard Carter in November 1922 revealed more than 5,000 objects, including the famous gold mask, golden shrines, chariots and jewellery. He restored the cult of Amun and moved the court back to Memphis, but the regime of the period was dominated by powerful officials such as Ay and the general Horemheb, both of whom became kings after him.

The Nineteenth Dynasty saw a revival of imperial ambitions under Seti I and especially his son Ramesses II, called Ramesses the Great, who ruled for sixty-six years from about 1279 to 1213 BCE. Ramesses fought the Hittites at the Battle of Kadesh around 1274 BCE, a clash of perhaps five thousand chariots that ended inconclusively although the king proclaimed it as a triumph on temple walls throughout Egypt. Some fifteen years later he concluded a peace treaty with the Hittite king Hattusili III, the earliest surviving international peace treaty, a copy of which is displayed at the United Nations headquarters. Ramesses built extensively, founding a new capital at Pi-Ramesses in the Delta, completing the hypostyle hall at Karnak, and carving the temples of Abu Simbel in Nubia, where the colossal statues of the king face the rising sun.

Table 6.1: Selected pharaohs of the New Kingdom

Pharaoh	Dynasty	Approx. reign (BCE)	Best known for
Ahmose I	18th	1550–1525	Expelled the Hyksos, founded the New Kingdom
Hatshepsut	18th	1473–1458	Female pharaoh, expedition to Punt
Thutmose III	18th	1479–1425	Military campaigns, Battle of Megiddo
Amenhotep III	18th	1390–1352	Peak of prosperity, Luxor Temple
Akhenaten	18th	1353–1336	Worship of the Aten, city of Amarna
Tutankhamun	18th	1332–1323	Intact tomb found in 1922
Seti I	19th	1290–1279	Temple of Abydos, tomb KV17
Ramesses II	19th	1279–1213	Battle of Kadesh, Abu Simbel
Ramesses III	20th	1186–1155	Defeated the Sea Peoples

In the Twentieth Dynasty Ramesses III defeated the so-called Sea Peoples, groups of migrants and raiders who destabilised the eastern Mediterranean and contributed to the fall of the Hittite empire and several Bronze Age cities around 1177 BCE. Egypt survived, but the economy was strained by the costs of war, inflation, and corruption. A strike by the royal tomb workers at Deir el-Medina, the earliest recorded labour strike in history, took place because their grain rations were not delivered on time. Gradually the high priests of Amun at Thebes gained so much power that they ruled the south as virtual kings, and at the end of the Twentieth Dynasty in 1069 BCE the New Kingdom came to an end.

7. The Late Period, Persian Rule and the Ptolemies

The centuries after the New Kingdom, known as the Third Intermediate Period, from about 1069 to 664 BCE, were marked by political division. Kings of the Twenty-First Dynasty ruled from Tanis in the Delta, while the high priests of Amun held power in Thebes. Later dynasties were founded by Libyan chieftains, descendants of soldiers who had settled in Egypt, and Shoshenq I, the first king of the Twenty-Second Dynasty, is probably the Shishak of the Bible who campaigned in Palestine around 925 BCE. By the eighth century BCE, Egypt was split among several competing rulers.

In this fragmented landscape, the Kingdom of Kush in Nubia, with its capital at Napata, grew in strength. King Piye marched northward around 727 BCE and brought most of Egypt under his control, founding the Twenty-Fifth Dynasty, also called the Kushite or Nubian dynasty. The Kushite pharaohs, among them Shabaka, Taharqa and Tanutamun, saw themselves as restorers of Egyptian tradition, and they built temples and revived the pyramid as a royal tomb in Nubia. However, their rule was challenged by the rising power of Assyria, whose armies invaded Egypt in 671 BCE and sacked Thebes in 663 BCE.

Psamtik I, a native Egyptian ruler who had been installed by the Assyrians, gradually asserted independence and founded the Twenty-Sixth Dynasty at Sais in 664 BCE. The Saite period was a time of cultural revival in which artists looked back to the Old Kingdom for inspiration and the administration was reorganised. Greek mercenaries and traders were welcomed, and a trading city, Naukratis, was established in the Delta. This independence ended when the Persian king Cambyses II conquered Egypt in 525 BCE after the Battle of Pelusium, and Egypt became a satrapy of the Persian Empire. A second period of native rule from 404 to 343 BCE was ended by a second Persian conquest.

In 332 BCE, Alexander the Great entered Egypt, where he was welcomed as a liberator from the Persians. He founded the city of Alexandria on the Mediterranean coast, visited the oracle of Amun at the Siwa Oasis, and was

proclaimed a son of the god. After Alexander's death in 323 BCE, his general Ptolemy took control of Egypt, and in 305 BCE he declared himself king, founding the Ptolemaic dynasty that ruled for nearly three centuries. The Ptolemies ruled from Alexandria, which became the greatest city of the Mediterranean world, famed for its Library and Museum and for the Pharos lighthouse, one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World.

The Ptolemies combined Greek and Egyptian traditions. They built temples in Egyptian style, such as those at Edfu, Dendera and Philae, and presented themselves as pharaohs to their Egyptian subjects while maintaining Greek as the language of government. The Rosetta Stone, a decree issued in 196 BCE under Ptolemy V, is inscribed in hieroglyphs, Demotic and Greek and reflects this multilingual world. The dynasty was weakened by family quarrels, and by the first century BCE Egypt depended increasingly on Roman protection.

The last Ptolemaic ruler, Cleopatra VII, who reigned from 51 to 30 BCE, was an intelligent and politically skilful monarch who spoke several languages and was the first of her dynasty to learn Egyptian. She allied herself with Julius Caesar and later with Mark Antony, with whom she had three children. After their defeat by Octavian at the Battle of Actium in 31 BCE, Octavian invaded Egypt, and in 30 BCE both Antony and Cleopatra died by suicide. Egypt became a province of the Roman Empire, ending the age of the pharaohs, although the traditional religion continued in the south until the sixth century CE, when the temple of Isis at Philae was finally closed.

8. Religion, Death and the Afterlife

Religion permeated every aspect of Egyptian life. The Egyptians worshipped hundreds of deities, many of whom were associated with natural forces, animals or abstract concepts. Ra, the sun god, travelled across the sky in a boat by day and through the underworld by night; Osiris, the god of the dead and resurrection, ruled the afterlife; his wife Isis was the model of devoted motherhood and magical power; their son Horus was the divine king; Hathor was the goddess of love, music and joy; and Anubis, the jackal-headed god, guided the dead and presided over mummification. The gods often appear in composite forms, with human bodies and animal heads, and they could merge, as in Amun-Ra, the combination of the hidden god of Thebes and the sun god.

The Egyptians believed that the universe was created from a primeval watery chaos called Nun, out of which the first mound of land emerged. Different cult centres developed their own creation stories: at Heliopolis the creator was Atum, who produced the first divine pair, Shu and Tefnut; at Memphis the god Ptah created the world by thought and speech; at Hermopolis eight primordial deities represented the elements of chaos. These accounts were not regarded as contradictory but as complementary explanations of a mystery. Maat, the principle of order, truth and justice, was personified as a goddess with an ostrich feather on her head, and the king's primary duty was to maintain Maat and defend it against Isfet, disorder.

Temples were regarded as the houses of the gods, and the cult statue in the innermost sanctuary was washed, clothed and fed each day by priests who acted on behalf of the king. Ordinary people were not admitted to the inner parts of the temple but took part in great festivals, when the god's statue was carried out in a portable barque in a procession. The Opet Festival at Thebes, in which the statue of Amun travelled from Karnak to Luxor, and the Beautiful Festival of the Valley, in which the dead were remembered, were among the grandest. Temples were also major economic institutions, owning land, workshops and storehouses.

Funerary beliefs were among the most elaborate in the ancient world. The Egyptians believed that a person consisted of several parts, including the physical body, the ka or life force, the ba or personality, often shown as a human-headed bird, and the name and shadow. To survive in the afterlife, the body had to be preserved, and the technique of mummification developed over centuries. The process, which took about seventy days, involved removing the brain and internal organs, drying the body with natron salt, and wrapping it in linen bandages with amulets placed between the layers. The organs were preserved in canopic jars, while the heart was left in the body because it was considered the seat of intelligence and morality.

In the Book of the Dead, a collection of spells that developed from the earlier Pyramid Texts and Coffin Texts, the dead person must pass through the judgement hall of Osiris. There the heart is weighed against the feather of Maat, and the deceased makes a declaration of innocence, denying forty-two sins. If the heart is lighter than the feather, the person is justified and admitted to the Field of Reeds, a perfected version of Egypt. If it is heavy with guilt, it is devoured by the monster Ammit, a creature part crocodile, part lion and part hippopotamus. Tombs were filled with food, furniture and tools to meet the needs of the dead, and ushabti figurines were provided to do the work required of the deceased in the next world.

9. Society, Economy and Daily Life

Egyptian society was organised as a pyramid. At the top stood the king and the royal family, supported by a class of high officials, priests and military commanders who owned estates and received appointments from the crown. Below them were scribes, craftsmen, merchants and soldiers, while the vast majority of the population consisted of peasant farmers who worked the land and owed labour and taxes to the state. Slavery existed, mainly in the form of prisoners of war and debtors, but it was not the basis of the economy in the way it was in classical Greece and Rome. Social mobility was possible: a talented boy educated as a scribe could rise to high office, and many inscriptions praise men who had risen from humble origins.

The economy was based on agriculture. The main crops were emmer wheat and barley, which were used to make bread and beer, the staples of the Egyptian diet. Farmers also grew flax for linen, vegetables such as onions, leeks, lentils and cucumbers, and fruit including dates, figs and grapes. Cattle, sheep, goats, pigs and geese were raised, and fish from the Nile and marsh birds provided additional protein. Irrigation was carried out by digging basins and canals, and a lever device called the shaduf, introduced during the New Kingdom, made it easier to lift water to higher fields. Taxes were collected in kind as grain, cattle or labour, and stored in royal and temple granaries.

Coinage was not used until the Late Period, so trade took place through barter, using standard units of value such as the deben, a weight of about 91 grams of copper. Expeditions were sent to the Sinai for turquoise and copper, to the eastern desert for gold, to Lebanon for cedar, and to Nubia for gold, ivory and ebony. State-sponsored trade was supplemented by local markets where farmers and craftsmen exchanged goods. Craftsmen worked in workshops attached to temples and palaces, producing pottery, jewellery, furniture, textiles and tools, and some, like the tomb builders of Deir el-Medina, formed a distinct community with their own laws and traditions.

Table 9.1: Staple foods and resources of ancient Egypt

Category	Examples	Use
Cereals	Emmer wheat, barley	Bread, beer, tax payments
Vegetables	Onions, leeks, lentils, cucumbers	Daily diet
Fruit	Dates, figs, grapes, pomegranates	Food, wine
Animals	Cattle, sheep, goats, geese	Meat, milk, leather, offerings
Fibres	Flax, papyrus	Linen, rope, paper, boats
Minerals	Gold, copper, turquoise, limestone, granite	Jewellery, tools, monuments

Family life was central. Houses were built of mud brick, and the ordinary home consisted of a few rooms with a roof used for sleeping in hot weather. Marriage was a private arrangement without an official ceremony, and monogamy was the norm, although kings often had several wives. Women had a more favourable legal position than in many ancient societies: they could own and inherit property, make contracts, initiate divorce and appear as witnesses in court. Most women worked in the household or in textile production, but some became priestesses, and a few, like Hatshepsut and Cleopatra, ruled as pharaohs.

Children were valued, and boys of the middle class could attend school to become scribes, where they learned to read and write by copying classic texts. Clothing was made from linen and was light and simple, with men wearing kilts and women wearing sheath dresses, though styles became more elaborate in the New Kingdom. Both men and women wore eye makeup of kohl, which also helped to protect against glare and infection. Entertainment included music, dance, banquets and board games such as senet and mehen, and a famous senet board was found in the tomb of Tutankhamun. Hunting, fishing and boating on the Nile were popular among the upper classes.

10. Writing, Art, Architecture and Science

The Egyptian writing system was one of the earliest in the world, and it is among the most visually striking. Hieroglyphs, from the Greek for sacred carvings, combined signs that represent sounds with signs that represent whole words and signs that indicate the category of a word. The Egyptians themselves called their script the words of the god, and it was used mainly for monumental inscriptions on temples and tombs. For everyday use, scribes developed cursive scripts: hieratic, a simplified form used from the Old Kingdom on, and later Demotic, which appeared in the seventh century BCE. Scribes wrote with reed pens and carbon-based ink on papyrus, a paper-like material made from the pith of the papyrus plant.

Egyptian literature included narrative tales such as the Story of Sinuhe and the Tale of the Shipwrecked Sailor, wisdom texts such as the Instruction of Ptahhotep, hymns, love poetry, magical spells and historical records. The Instruction of Ptahhotep, attributed to a vizier of the Fifth Dynasty, offers advice on proper conduct, urging humility, honesty and generosity. The love poems of the New Kingdom, in which lovers call each other brother and sister, express a delicate emotion and have often been compared to the Song of Songs.

Egyptian art followed strict conventions that remained remarkably stable. Figures were shown according to a canon of proportions, with the head in profile, the eye and shoulders frontal and the legs in profile, in order to display every part of the body clearly. Hierarchical scale was used so that the king appeared larger than his subjects. Colours had symbolic meanings: green represented new life, red signified chaos and power, blue and gold signified divinity, and black represented fertility and the underworld. Though conventional, Egyptian art was not static, and every period had its own style, from the massive forms of the Old Kingdom to the sensitive portraits of the Middle Kingdom and the elegant sophistication of the New Kingdom.

In architecture, the Egyptians were masters of stone construction. Temples followed a standard plan with an avenue of sphinxes leading to a pylon gateway,

an open court, a hypostyle hall filled with columns that imitated papyrus and lotus plants, and a dark inner sanctuary. The Hypostyle Hall at Karnak contains 134 columns, the tallest of which reach about 21 metres. Obelisks, tall tapering shafts of granite capped by a gilded pyramidion, were erected in pairs at temple entrances, and the largest surviving example, the unfinished obelisk in Aswan, would have measured about 42 metres and weighed over 1,000 tonnes.

The Egyptians made practical advances in mathematics, astronomy and medicine. They used a decimal number system, could calculate the areas of triangles, rectangles and circles, and estimated pi at about 3.16, as shown in the Rhind Mathematical Papyrus, copied around 1550 BCE. They devised a calendar of 365 days, divided into twelve months of thirty days with five extra days, that is the ancestor of the modern calendar, and they tracked the rising of the star Sirius, which heralded the Nile flood. Medical papyri such as the Edwin Smith Papyrus, which describes the treatment of wounds and injuries in a rational manner, and the Ebers Papyrus, which lists hundreds of remedies, show a mixture of empirical observation and magic. Egyptian doctors had a high reputation across the ancient Near East.

Table 10.1: The Egyptian writing systems

Script	Period	Material	Use
Hieroglyphic	c. 3200 BCE – 4th century CE	Stone, wood, papyrus	Monumental and religious texts
Hieratic	c. 2700 BCE – 3rd century CE	Papyrus, ostraca	Administrative and literary texts
Demotic	c. 650 BCE – 5th century CE	Papyrus, ostraca	Legal, commercial, literary texts
Coptic	2nd century CE onward	Papyrus, parchment	Christian texts, Egyptian with Greek letters

11. Warfare, Diplomacy and Foreign Relations

Egypt's relations with its neighbours were shaped by geography, trade and the search for security. In the earliest periods the army was a modest force raised for specific campaigns, and warfare consisted mainly of raids against Nubia and the Sinai to secure access to gold, copper and turquoise. The Old Kingdom autobiography of Weni, an official of the Sixth Dynasty, describes a campaign against the Asiatics of southern Canaan in which the king mobilised troops from all of Egypt and even from Nubia, showing that the state could raise large levies when needed. Yet the Old Kingdom had no standing army in the later sense, and officials and provincial governors often combined civil and military duties.

The Middle Kingdom saw the first systematic effort to control Nubia. The fortresses built by Senusret III along the Second Cataract were enormous mud-brick structures with thick walls, bastions, ditches and glacis designed to withstand sieges, and they housed garrisons that regulated trade and movement along the river. Inscriptions at the fortress of Semna forbade Nubians from sailing north past the border except for trading purposes. These installations demonstrate a sophisticated understanding of defensive architecture and an effort to project royal authority far beyond the traditional boundaries of the country.

The experience of the Hyksos occupation transformed Egyptian military practice. In the New Kingdom a professional army was organised, equipped with bronze weapons, composite bows, body armour and the light two-wheeled chariot drawn by two horses. The army was divided into infantry and chariot divisions, each named after a god such as Amun, Ra, Ptah and Seth, and was commanded by the king, who often led in person. Soldiers were recruited from Egyptian conscripts and from foreign mercenaries, including Nubian archers known as the Medjay, who also served as a kind of police force protecting the royal necropolis at Thebes. Veterans were rewarded with grants of land and captured goods.

Table 11.1: Major military engagements of the New Kingdom

Battle / campaign	Approx. date (BCE)	Pharaoh	Opponent	Outcome
Siege of Avaris	c. 1550	Ahmose I	Hyksos	Egyptian victory, Hyksos expelled
Battle of Megiddo	c. 1457	Thutmose III	Canaanite coalition	Egyptian victory
Battle of Kadesh	c. 1274	Ramesses II	Hittites	Inconclusive, both claimed victory
Libyan wars	c. 1208	Merneptah	Libyans and Sea Peoples	Egyptian victory
Battles of the Delta and Djahy	c. 1177	Ramesses III	Sea Peoples	Egyptian victory

Diplomacy was as important as war. The Amarna letters, some 350 clay tablets in Akkadian cuneiform discovered at the site of Akhetaten in 1887, record correspondence between the pharaoh and the great kings of Babylonia, Assyria, Mitanni and Hatti, who addressed each other as brothers. The letters show that gifts were exchanged on a lavish scale, that rulers constantly complained about the quality or quantity of the gold they received, and that marriage alliances were used to cement friendships. Egyptian kings, however, rarely sent their own daughters abroad, a policy that Babylonian kings found offensive. Smaller vassal rulers in Canaan wrote anxious letters begging for troops and describing threats from rivals.

The treaty between Ramesses II and Hattusili III, concluded in about 1259 BCE, is the best-preserved example of a Bronze Age peace treaty. It was recorded in both Egyptian hieroglyphs on the walls of Karnak and in Akkadian on clay tablets found at the Hittite capital Hattusa. The agreement established a defensive alliance, a promise of mutual assistance in case of attack and the extradition of fugitives, and it invoked the gods of both countries as witnesses. The relationship was sealed by the marriage of Ramesses to a Hittite princess in the thirty-fourth year of his reign.

In later periods Egypt was more often the object than the instrument of foreign policy. Assyrian, Persian, Macedonian and Roman armies each conquered the country in turn, drawn by its wealth and strategic position. Even so, the Egyptians proved remarkably resilient, assimilating foreign rulers into the traditional pattern of kingship and preserving their language, religion and customs. Under the

Ptolemies, Egyptian soldiers returned to prominence in the army, and the Battle of Raphia in 217 BCE, where Egyptian troops fought alongside Greek and Macedonian units against the Seleucids, marked an important step in the integration of the two populations.

12. Rediscovery and Legacy

After the end of the pharaonic period, the ability to read hieroglyphs was gradually lost. The last known hieroglyphic inscription was carved at the temple of Philae in 394 CE, and over the following centuries knowledge of the script faded, partly because the new Christian culture and later the Arab conquest of 641 CE changed the language of administration and religion. Europeans knew ancient Egypt mainly through the writings of Greek and Roman authors such as Herodotus, Diodorus and Plutarch, and through the Bible. Medieval Arab scholars, by contrast, took an interest in the monuments, and several, such as Abd al-Latif al-Baghdadi in the twelfth century, wrote accurate descriptions of the pyramids.

The modern study of Egypt began with Napoleon Bonaparte's expedition of 1798, which was accompanied by 167 scholars and scientists who recorded the monuments in a monumental publication, the Description de l'Égypte. In 1799, French soldiers rebuilding a fort at Rashid, known to Europeans as Rosetta, discovered a slab of black granodiorite inscribed with the same decree in hieroglyphic, Demotic and Greek. The stone was surrendered to the British in 1801 and has been in the British Museum since 1802. The Greek text made it possible to attempt a translation of the other scripts.

The decipherment was achieved by the French scholar Jean-François Champollion, who announced his breakthrough in 1822 in a famous letter. Building on the earlier work of the English polymath Thomas Young, who had identified the name of Ptolemy in a cartouche, Champollion realised that hieroglyphs were not merely symbolic but represented sounds as well as ideas. His knowledge of Coptic, the last stage of the Egyptian language, was decisive. His grammar and dictionary laid the foundations of Egyptology as a scientific discipline. The Egyptian Museum, founded in Cairo in 1858 by the French Egyptologist Auguste Mariette, and the Antiquities Service he established, helped to protect the heritage in the country itself.

Archaeology developed gradually from treasure hunting to a systematic discipline. Sir William Matthew Flinders Petrie, working from the 1880s, introduced careful

excavation methods and sequence dating based on pottery, and trained a generation of archaeologists. Howard Carter's discovery of Tutankhamun's tomb in 1922, funded by Lord Carnarvon, brought ancient Egypt to the attention of the world and stimulated a wave of Egyptomania in design and popular culture. In the twentieth century, the construction of the Aswan High Dam, begun in 1960, threatened to submerge the temples of Nubia, and an international campaign organised by UNESCO moved the temples of Abu Simbel and Philae to higher ground between 1964 and 1968.

Today, new technologies continue to transform the study of ancient Egypt. Radiocarbon dating refines the chronology, DNA analysis is providing information about family relationships and population history, computed tomography scanning allows researchers to examine mummies without unwrapping them, and satellite imagery has revealed thousands of unknown sites. In November 2022 the Grand Egyptian Museum near the Giza plateau, the largest archaeological museum in the world dedicated to a single civilisation, completed its main construction and began to prepare for its full opening, and it houses the complete collection of Tutankhamun's treasures.

The legacy of ancient Egypt endures. The Egyptians' solar calendar influenced the Julian calendar and through it our own. Their ideas about monumental architecture inspired later Greek and Roman builders, and obelisks stand in cities from Rome to Paris to New York. Words such as paper, from papyrus, and chemistry, possibly from Kemet, may derive from Egyptian sources. Above all, the civilisation remains a source of fascination for people everywhere, and for Egyptians today it is a vital part of national identity and a central pillar of cultural tourism, which brings millions of visitors every year to see the pyramids, temples and tombs.

Concluding remarks

The history of ancient Egypt is a story of continuity and change. For three thousand years, the Egyptians maintained a remarkably consistent system of belief, art and kingship, while adapting to crises, foreign rulers and technological developments. The achievements of the pyramid builders, the scribes, the priests

and the farmers of the Nile Valley have shaped the human story, and the ongoing work of archaeologists, historians and conservators continues to reveal new aspects of this extraordinary civilisation.